



SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

Navigating a tectonic shift in sports ecosystem

During the 'New Frontiers in Sports: Play, Fitness and More' panel at the PlayCom 2025: Business of Sports Summit, Neha Parab Kandalgaonkar (third left), the vice president and head of corporate communications at Procam International, highlighted a tectonic shift in India's definition of sport.

"If somebody told me 20 years ago that a 65-year-old would want to run a half-marathon, triathlon or any other endurance sport, it would have been unheard of. But that has been possible today."

Deepak Raj (left), country head of IRONMAN India and HYROX, said the inception of the latter, a global, mass-participation indoor fitness race, has given gym enthusiasts something to be excited about.

"When we brought the IRONMAN to India, there were only a few triathletes. Even the gym-goers never had a race or a sport despite being really disciplined and active. They do now," he said in a panel moderated by Aparajita Biswas (right), Marketing Head of *The Hindu Group*.

Parvin Dabas (third right), co-founder of the Pro Panja League, thanked the Government for fuelling the growth of non-conventional sports in the country. Furthermore, Dabas revealed that India has secured the hosting rights of the

World Armwrestling Championship next year.

That spirit of diversification is not confined to armwrestling alone. Another sport steadily carving its niche in India is pickleball, an emerging trend that has trickled down to peri-urban locales through Instagram reels and YouTube shorts.

"If you have played badminton, squash, tennis or table tennis, it's easier. What that has done is, it has made pickleball very inclusive at the beginning stage itself," Sameer Pathak (second left), an administrator of the sport, said. Tuhin Mishra (second right), managing director and co-founder at Baseline Ventures and Director of the Prime Volleyball League (PVL), underlined balance as a priority.

"In India, our league's viewership is split 57-43 between men and women. It's one of those sports which is not skewed (gender-wise), which means that we can actually involve more women as well to take up the sport," Mishra said.

